prime minister had reached out to them and I found strength in the fact that many vulnerable nations depended on India in times of adversity.'

'You did face several challenges though, Mr Prime Minister…' I asked.

'Yes. There were certainly many. It remained very important for me that society stayed united. I knew that the pressure of living through a pandemic could only be released by shared experiences. That is how junta curfew and the lighting of the diyas came about. I also realized very early on that doctors were our biggest strength in this war against the virus and it was absolutely critical that people respect them as God. So, I dedicated the junta curfew to the doctors and frontline workers. In addition to that, I asked the Indian Air Force to do sorties and shower flowers from the sky in their honour and also personally held virtual meetings with doctors, nurses, ward staff and ambulance drivers. I was very conscious of what I needed to do to get the Indian people to respond in large numbers to my call to action. In fact, junta curfew was like a rice test—you know how you stick a knife in a vessel of rice to see if it is fully cooked? After the phenomenal response to the junta curfew, I was convinced that the people of the country were willing to put their trust in me. Armed with this knowledge, I kept my communications through the pandemic absolutely clear. I spoke to the people often—I probably did more national addresses in these two years of the pandemic than any other prime minister did through their entire term! Now, take for instance the mask mandate which many countries struggled with and continue to even today. Early on, as soon as our scientists told me that the virus was most likely spreading through aerosol droplets, it was important to mandate masks, but we didn't have as many N95 masks for all our people. If I came on television wearing an N95 mask, people would run to the stores and buy out the available quantities creating a shortage for our doctors, who needed them the most. I had read a scientific paper about the effectiveness of a cloth mask too, so I deliberately wore a shawl around my mouth and nose to demonstrate to the people of the country. I also followed it up and changed my social media profile pictures to an image of me wearing a cloth face-cover and didn't change it till we crossed 1 billion vaccine doses. I wanted to leave no room for doubt that face masks were absolutely essential in our fight against COVID-19.'

My extended conversation with the prime minister features at several places in the book. I have found that his perspective provides meaning behind many of our government's initiatives during the course of the